TEACHING SCRIPT | LESSON 14

# 2 Corinthians Part 2

*A 50 Minute Teaching Script*

**BIG IDEA** The grace of Christ creates generous people and faithful servants who boast not in themselves but in Christ's power displayed through weakness.

**BEFORE CLASS** Write on the board: What does genuine Christian strength look like? Under it write: How does the gospel reshape generosity, authority, and strength?

## 0:00-5:00 Opening question prayer and transition

Good morning. Last week, 2 Corinthians 1-7 showed God's power working through weak and suffering servants. Chapters 8-13 apply that same truth to money, leadership, reputation, and persistent pain.

Our opening question is: What does genuine Christian strength look like? Let the class offer descriptions. If needed, prompt with confidence, success, endurance, honesty, sacrifice, and dependence on God.

Our controlling question is: How does the gospel reshape generosity, authority, and strength? Paul will answer through three movements: grace produces generous giving, the cross overturns impressive ministry, and Christ's power rests on weakness.

Let's pray. Father, free us from protecting and promoting ourselves. Form Christ's generosity, humility, and faithfulness in us. Teach us to trust the sufficiency of his grace. Amen.

## 5:00-16:00 Grace produces generous giving

Set the scene. Paul was organizing a collection from predominantly Gentile churches for poor Jewish believers in Jerusalem. The gift met real need and made the unity of Jewish and Gentile Christians visible. The Corinthians had promised to participate but had not finished.

Read 8:1-9. Paul begins with God's grace among the Macedonians. Their severe trial and deep poverty overflowed in joy because they first gave themselves to the Lord. Their beyond-their-means gift is an extraordinary example, not a required amount for every believer.

Grace-shaped giving is willing, proportionate, sometimes sacrificial, and directed toward genuine need. Verse 12 says the gift is accepted according to what a person has, not what the person does not have. Paul does not use guilt to make the generous poor.

Verse 9 provides the gospel center. Christ was rich in divine glory but became poor through incarnation, humble service, suffering, and the cross. Through his poverty we receive salvation's riches. Paul is not claiming Jesus was a wealthy man or promising that donors will become rich. Christ's self-giving grace creates self-giving people.

Equality in verses 13-15 does not mean compulsory sameness. The manna quotation shows God's provision meeting need. Today one believer's abundance supplies another; circumstances may later reverse.

## 16:00-23:00 Integrity cheerful giving and thanksgiving

Summarize 8:16-9:5. Titus and two trusted brothers help administer the gift. Paul is careful to do what is right before God and visibly honorable before people. Financial integrity requires more than sincere intentions. Multiple people, clear procedures, and accountability protect everyone involved.

Read 9:6-11. Sowing and reaping is not a prosperity formula. God can supply sufficiency so believers abound in every good work. They are enriched so that they can be generous, needs are met, and thanksgiving rises to God.

The prosperity version says, Give so that God will upgrade your life. Paul says God supplies what is needed so that generosity and good work can continue. The harvest includes righteousness, fellowship, thanksgiving, and glory to God.

A cheerful giver is not careless or manipulated. Each person decides before God and gives willingly rather than reluctantly or under compulsion.

## 23:00-31:00 Gospel authority and spiritual warfare

Explain the tone change. Chapters 10-13 probably address a resistant minority still influenced by rival teachers. Some scholars propose that these chapters came from another letter, but the class does not need to reconstruct the correspondence. Teach the canonical letter's clear movement from restored relationship to unfinished opposition.

Read 10:3-5. Paul's weapons are not intimidation, manipulation, status, or polished self-promotion. God's power demolishes arguments and proud claims raised against knowing God.

Taking every thought captive can apply to our personal minds, but the immediate issue is a whole system of thinking that judged ministry by worldly power and resisted the gospel. Spiritual warfare here means bringing false ideas, arguments, and loyalties into obedience to Christ.

Paul's authority is not the freedom to dominate. The Lord gave it for building the church, and it operates through the meekness and gentleness of Christ.

## 31:00-39:00 Super-apostles and foolish boasting

Summarize 11:1-15. The super-apostles were probably rival teachers whom Paul names sarcastically. We cannot reconstruct their complete theology. They claimed impressive credentials, speech, experiences, and authority while attacking Paul's weakness and financial practice.

The decisive issue is not style. They proclaimed another Jesus, a different spirit, and a different gospel. They exploited the church and masqueraded as apostles of Christ. Religious polish cannot rescue a counterfeit gospel or abusive leadership.

Read portions of 11:21-30. Paul reluctantly enters their boasting contest. He can match their Jewish credentials, but then he overturns the contest by listing beatings, dangers, hunger, sleeplessness, and anxiety for the churches.

Paul does not teach that pain automatically proves faithfulness. His sufferings reveal costly service to Christ and others. His final story is almost comic: the mighty apostle escapes Damascus by being lowered through a window in a basket. The servant resembles the crucified Lord rather than a conquering celebrity.

## 39:00-47:00 The thorn sufficient grace and authority that builds

Summarize 12:1-6. Paul speaks indirectly about being caught up to the third heaven or paradise. He stresses what he received and refuses to disclose what he heard. The vision cannot become a platform for spiritual celebrity.

Read 12:7-10. The thorn has been interpreted as physical illness, persistent opposition or persecution, or an inward spiritual or emotional affliction. Illness and opposition may have the strongest cases, but Paul does not identify it. Do not spend the class diagnosing him.

What we know is more important. The thorn was painful and persistent. Satan used it to harass Paul; God used it to prevent conceit. Paul prayed repeatedly for removal. Christ answered with sustaining grace rather than immediate deliverance.

My grace is sufficient does not call pain good, forbid prayer, or reject practical help. Christ promises that his grace will be enough for endurance and that his power reaches its intended display where Paul cannot pretend to be self-sufficient.

In 13:5, Paul turns the Corinthians' demand for proof back on them: examine yourselves. Have they remained in the apostolic faith? Is Christ genuinely among them? Will they repent? This is a serious call to gospel faithfulness, not an invitation to endless anxious introspection.

Paul's authority is for building up, not tearing down. Discipline is possible, but restoration is the goal. The letter ends with the grace of Christ, the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit.

## 47:00-50:00 Synthesis homework and prayer

Here is the lesson in one sentence: the gospel frees Christians to give without securing themselves, serve without promoting themselves, and remain faithful without pretending to be strong.

Before next week, read Romans 1-4. Mark humanity's problem, God's righteousness, the role of faith, and Paul's use of Abraham.

Let's pray. Lord Jesus, thank you for becoming poor for us and for giving grace that is sufficient. Make us generous without compulsion, honest in stewardship, humble in leadership, and faithful in weakness. Let your power, not our image, be seen in us. Amen.